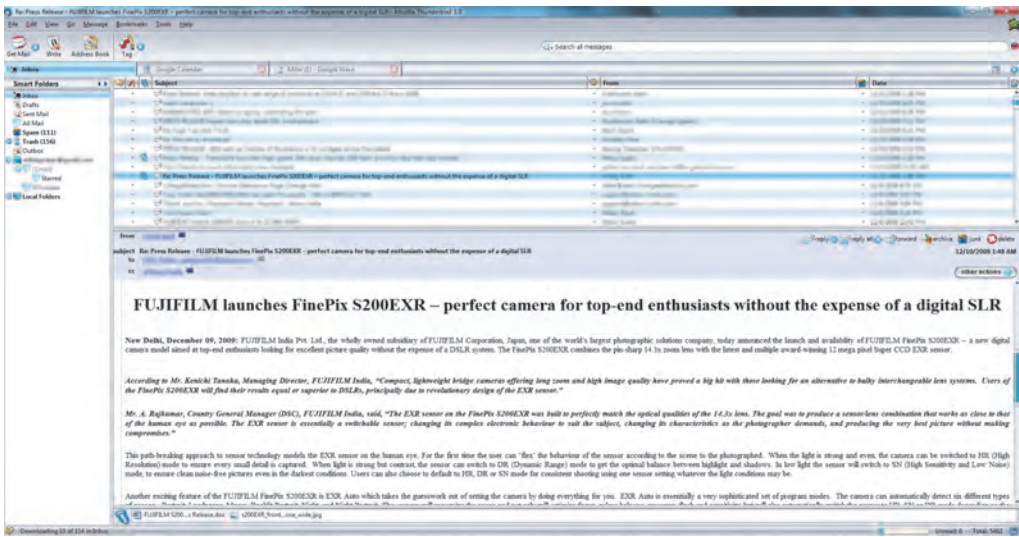




Noia 2.0 is an interesting theme for Thunderbird

Exciting themes

Just like Firefox, Mozilla has made Thunderbird completely skinnable. This has led to many independent fans come up with themes for the email client over the years. While Thunderbird 3 does not support older themes yet, there are quite a few of the old favourites that would still catch anyone's fancy. The one that stands out, in our opinion, is Noia 2.0 eXtreme. A must-have!

Ubuntu 9.10

The release of Canonical's Ubuntu 9.10 coincided with the release of the latest Windows OS and prompted comparisons between the two. In fact, some even suggested trying out Ubuntu as a replacement for those who are not satisfied with Microsoft's operating system.

Boot options

If you're satisfied with the Live CD experience, and choose to install the OS to the disk along with any existing OS, you will feel miffed. During installation, Ubuntu succeeds in annoying the user by displaying what is hallmark Windows behaviour - messing

up the bootloader. The boot loader installation cannot be tweaked, so one cannot change the default boot option - which is Ubuntu. Dedicated tools to modify the boot menu are available in some distros like PCLinux and Opensuse, but in Ubuntu one needs to do the modification manually using the text editor and command line. Additionally, those who are familiar with editing the `/boot/grub/menu.cfg` file will be clueless here. The reason : Ubuntu uses GRUB2 which works differently and doesn't use a `menu.lst` file.

In Ubuntu to get the default OS entry right, you need to edit the `/etc/default/grub` file. This file is not quite helpful because it does not list the boot entries. So either recall the entries in the boot menu displayed when you booted, or open the `/boot/grub/grub.cfg` file to figure out the exact entries and their sequence. In the `grub.cfg` file, the "menu entry" prefix denotes the entries in the boot menu. The first entry is numbered 0, and the second 1 and so on. Once the required default entry number is arrived at,

this figure can be added to the line `GRUB_DEFAULT=1` replacing the 1. This line is in the `/etc/default/grub` file, not the `grub.cfg` file. The default interval of 10 secs can be adjusted by tweaking the `GRUB_TIMEOUT=10` line, in the `/etc/default/grub` file.

Of course, there is a possibility that the GRUB routine gets the boot parameters wrong. In the case of the writer's system already containing a PCLinux installation, GRUB did not properly detect the boot parameters leaving the PCLinux installation inaccessible. In such cases the menu can be modified by editing the `/etc/grub.d/40_custom` file to include the corrected menu entry. This is a bit advanced, but for minor editions, like in the writer's case, the relevant entries from the `grub.cfg` can be copied over to the `40_custom` file and necessary changes made.

Once all modifications are completed, the command `grub-update` needs to be run to ensure that the changes are incorporated in the `/boot/grub/grub.cfg` file which is the basis of the boot menu.

Root password?

In the Linux world the root account is held in high esteem. In 9.10 the all powerful root account is practically insignificant - the first user becomes the defacto root. Unfortunately, if one doesn't know this fact, it can be quite frustrating trying to figure out what the default root password is (a online search reveals `root-mein`), since the installation routine doesn't seek one and trying the user password is the last thing on a Linux user's mind. Also try logging in as root or su, and you won't get much far. The solution is to use the "sudo su" command to stay on with higher privileges for a longer period.

The right Resolution

Getting the video right can be considered as a top most priority for a distro, and when two year old distros manage to get it right, one would expect the latest distros to atleast do as much, especially since the hardware is not cutting edge. But, Ubuntu 9.10 (or 9.04 for that matter), fails to detect the max resolution on two of the systems this writer tried installing the OS on. Now had this been PCLinux or Opensuse, the tools to modify the graphics properties would be available within the GUI, but this is Ubuntu. So one needs to be prepared for some command line action. There are a few surprises in store here as well. For one, the familiar `xorg.conf` file is missing. So to create a `xorg.conf` file, one needs to run the `X-configure` command after logging in as superuser. As in the writer's case, even this doesn't always work, in which case the best option is to download the relevant